

She said she was so stressed out that ten days before they were about to be married, she woke up in the middle of the night and told my dad she couldn't marry him. (I'd never heard this story before, by the way, so it was fun to learn that I almost didn't exist.) To ease her panic, my dad uninvited the extra 125 people the next day. (Good dude!) Still, the event was such a burden that my mom spent the whole time on Valium, which her grandmother gave to her. (Good lady!) She described her wedding day as "the worst."

WHO IS PAYING FOR THIS DOG AND PONY SHOW?

Now, when tradition is less dominant and self-expression and non-normativity are increasingly in, who's *actually* paying for all this? Is it still the bride's family? Wedding expert Anne Chertoff says it's a mix. (Of course, this is all made especially confusing if there are two brides or no brides at all.)

Most often the bride's parents cover around 40 to 50 percent of the budget, the groom's parents cover about 10 to 15 percent, and then the couple—especially these days when couples are getting married later, once they are more financially independent—pays for the rest. Of course, many couples pay for their own weddings entirely, either because they want to or because their families can't afford to foot the bill.

There's no set rule when it comes to spending for a wedding. Some people advise using a ratio to create a budget based on your income, and others suggest setting aside a savings account for it early on. Chertoff said one way to ease the financial burden is to have different family members pitch in for different things if possible. Maybe a grandmother wants to buy a dress and an uncle wants to cover the cake. Other than food and venue, the two chief expenses, wedding photography is currently the fastest-growing expense due to the rise of Instagram and Pinterest.

YouTubers Will and RJ, who spent \$20,000 on their nuptials, described in their video the unique wedding-planning obstacles they faced as a gay couple. They recommend being upfront with vendors about being a same-sex couple to avoid any horrible Kim Davis–like experiences. (You remember that county clerk who refused to give marriage licenses to same-sex couples? FUN!)